D02 · Planning Maturity & Digital Transformation

# 05 · Planning talent model & operating rhythm

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## 1 WHAT IT IS

A planning talent model and operating rhythm define the capabilities, roles, and recurring cadence that make a mature planning process run — shifting planners from transaction executors to exception and decision managers, and codifying the meeting cadence, decision rights, and governance — so the capability lives in people and routines, not only in the software the transformation bought.

## 2 WHY IT MATTERS

Teece, Pisano & Shuen 1997 **(Teece, Pisano & Shuen, 1997 — peer-reviewed)**, in the dynamic-capabilities framework, established that an organization's real capability resides in its processes, routines, and skills — not in its assets, which competitors can also buy. Applied to planning, the platform is an asset anyone can purchase; the durable capability is the talent and the operating rhythm that use it. Transformations that fund tool and process but leave the talent model and cadence unchanged get a new platform operated at the maturity of the old one: planners still grinding transactions instead of managing exceptions, the same meetings producing the same non-decisions. The cost is the gap between installed and realized capability — **an expensive platform delivering a fraction of its value because the people and routines never matured to match it**.

## 3 HOW IT IS DONE

1. **Redefine the planner role from executor to exception manager.** A mature platform automates the transactions; the planner's value moves to judgment — managing exceptions, interpreting scenarios, owning decisions. Define the new role explicitly, or the platform automates the work while the planners keep doing it by hand anyway.
2. **Map the capability gap and close it deliberately.** The new role needs analytical, statistical, and business-partnering skills the transaction role did not. Assess the gap and build the skills through hiring and development — capability is a funded investment, not a one-week training at go-live.
3. **Codify the operating rhythm.** Define the recurring cadence — the S&OP/IBP calendar, the data cut-offs, the reviews — as a fixed rhythm with named owners. The rhythm is the routine that makes maturity repeatable rather than dependent on individual heroics each cycle.
4. **Assign decision rights explicitly.** Define who decides what at each step — what a planner owns, what escalates, what the executive S&OP ratifies. Ambiguous decision rights are why mature-looking processes still produce non-decisions; clarity is what lets the rhythm actually resolve trade-offs.
5. **Build flexibility into the talent model.** Cross-train across planning roles and regions so the rhythm survives absence and attrition. A process that depends on one irreplaceable expert is fragile; a cross-trained team is a resilient capability, the human analog of flexible capacity.
6. **Make capability and rhythm part of the maturity assessment.** Assess the organization and operating-rhythm dimensions with the same rigor as process and technology. A transformation that measures tool adoption but not role change and cadence discipline is tracking the asset and ignoring the capability that determines whether the asset delivers.

**WORKED EXAMPLE — ILLUSTRATIVE**

A company completed a platform and process transformation but left the talent model untouched — **baseline: planners still manually building outputs the platform could generate, meetings producing the same non-decisions, realized value far below the business case**. It redefined the planner role around exception management, closed the analytical skill gap, codified the operating rhythm and decision rights, and built cross-training. Results: **planners shifted from grinding transactions to managing exceptions and decisions, meeting time fell while decision quality rose, and the platform finally delivered the value its business case promised** — because the capability matured to match the asset.

**IN PRACTICE**

### Explicit role redefinition

Rewrite the planner role description around exception management, scenario judgment, and decision ownership, and staff and develop against it. The role change is the hinge of the whole transformation — without it, the platform automates work no one stops doing manually, and the installed capability stays unrealized.

### Funded capability building

Treat the analytical and business-partnering skill gap as a funded program — hiring, development, and time to learn — not a go-live training session. The skills the mature role needs take longer to build than the platform takes to install, which means capability building must start before, not after, the system goes live.

### Codified rhythm and decision rights

Document the operating cadence and the decision rights at each step, with named owners. The rhythm and clear decision rights are what convert a mature-looking process into one that actually resolves trade-offs cycle after cycle, rather than re-litigating the same questions in every meeting.

### Cross-training for resilience

Cross-train across planning roles and regions so the operating rhythm survives absence and attrition. A capability concentrated in one expert is a single point of failure; a cross-trained team makes the routine — and therefore the maturity — resilient to the inevitable turnover.

#### WHAT YOU WOULD USE

**TALENT / OPERATING-RHYTHM ENABLEMENT**

**Planning platform collaboration & workflow (SAP IBP, o9, Kinaxis)** — The planning platforms themselves encode the operating rhythm — workflow, cadence, role-based collaboration, and exception management. **(SAP, o9, Kinaxis — vendor)** The choice when the rhythm and decision flow should be embedded in the same system that runs the plan.

**Skills & capability platforms (LMS, ASCM/APICS)** — Learning and certification platforms that build the analytical and planning capability the mature role requires. **(ASCM/APICS, LMS vendors — vendor)** A strong fit where the binding gap is planner capability rather than tooling or process.

**Operating-model / change-management specialists** — Consulting and change-management partners that redesign roles, decision rights, and operating rhythm. **(specialized vendors — vendor)** The vertical option when the operating-model redesign is the heart of the transformation and exceeds internal change capacity.

**For operations that don't need a platform** — A written role definition, a documented operating-rhythm calendar with decision rights, a skills matrix, and a development plan. The capability is built by deliberate role design, cadence discipline, and skill development — none of which require software, all of which require sustained management attention.

## 4 SO WHAT

**Operations that mature the talent model and operating rhythm get the value the platform promised; operations that fund the tool and leave the people and routines unchanged get an expensive asset operated at the old maturity.** The capability that competitors cannot copy is never the software — it is the planners who manage exceptions instead of grinding transactions and the rhythm that turns the process into a repeatable decision loop. The transformation is finished when the people and routines, not the platform, are what mature.

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